assumed Goldman Sachs' script as their own: very quickly, they began positing themselves (particularly in Moscow and Beijing) as a geopolitical counter to Western hegemony or, at least, as the potential platform for something like a new concert of nations in an increasingly multipolar world order. Indeed, by 2009, the international summits held on social and developmental agendas by Brazil, India and South Africa, and those held since 2006 by the governments of the BRIC countries at Russia's initiative, merged. Since then, BRICS refers both to a category and to an actual international forum, comprising a group of five emerging/emerged powers, representing just under half of the world's population and about a third of global economic activity (Larionova 2012; Lukov 2014). The older the BRICS forum gets, the more diverse the profile and trajectories of its members become. For this reason, a useful starting point is to ask what defines and unites the group, and what is Russia's standing in it.

Now, as in 2001, the BRIC(S) formula was problematic, temptingly offering an illusion of internal consistency between its economies, and helping to hide the extreme differences in productive structure, demographic outlook, developmental strategy and political regime which still distinguish its members (Cassiolato 2014:74; Armijo 2007; BRICS 2014). There are, nevertheless, at least two discernible unifying elements within the acronym. Firstly, and especially if one considers the intellectual aims of Jim O'Neill (then a leading researcher for Goldman Sachs' Global Economics), the BRICS category was a useful way of identifying the best mid- and long-term opportunities for capitalism's big investors. BRICS were, in this formal sense, a cogent group for economic strategists to pore over. Secondly, today, as in 2001, the BRICS remain recognisably unified as proponents of several regional variations on Western neoliberalism, keen on becoming integral (if differentiated) elements of the contemporary capitalist system. Indeed, as O'Neill has recently pointed out, 'in 2001, what particularly interested me about Brazil, Russia, India and China was that they all appeared increasingly eager to engage on the global stage' (2011).

Beyond these two considerations, almost everything within the BRICS is different – even their growth potential, central to their very definition, varies drastically. And meantime, although each of the BRICS is exceptional and has largely taken its own path over the years, in its own way Russia is arguably more exceptional than the others – its inclusion in the mix by Jim O'Neill certainly proved the most controversial. While each BRICS had its own particular legacy and set of challenges to face, the Russian Federation seemed economically much more vulnerable to turns of fortune, decidedly appearing to be the group's paper tiger (Boris Kagarlitsky has labelled it an 'empire of the periphery', 2008).